

Anurag Kashyap. "The problem is he wants to announce them the next morning."

He is a man in hurry. Which explains why unlike Priyadarshan who is adept at remaking his Malayalam blockbusters, Varma consistently fails to top his own Telugu films. When he remade *Shiva* last year (after his unhappiness with an assistant, Rohit Jugraj's version, *James*), it had critics wanting to shoot themselves in the head, and when he remade *Kshana Kshanam* as *Daud* in 1997, the seat-of-the-pants approach looked less charming and more charlatan. Yet it's symptomatic of a Bollywood where there is more money than talent, that he continues to attract financiers in droves. Varma's last hit was a film he directed in 2005, *Sarkar*. He has produced or directed nine flops since then, yet he continues to get backing. In 2007, for instance, *Nishabd* and *Aag* were produced by Adlabs, as are the forthcoming *Shabri* and *Sarkar Raj*, while *Darling* was financed by T-Series and *Go* is produced by Sushil Gupta of Photo Films whose son, Gaurav, is the lead actor. The 2005 agreement with Adlabs that entailed 10 films from him lies scrapped though. "We are not interested in small films from him or his assistants," says his close friend Manmohan Shetty, CEO of Adlabs. "We are paying for his talent and time."

Unfortunately, the talent seems to be focused on advertising, these days, as is evident from the way he made the Rs 30-crore *Aag* (in the first week it has recovered less than Rs 7 crore), spending more time on preparing for its look, hiring a company which is better known for its publicity design, than he did on writing the script. It also lies in marketing, in selling an idea. He is always seeking feedback (no interview in his office is complete without Varma himself putting on the television set to show promos of his latest movie or extending photographs of his latest discovery or latest look) but then does precisely what he wants. For instance, he collaborated with Rajeev Chudasama of Marching Ants for the look of *Aag* (down to flying in 600 kg of moss from Manipur for Babban Singh's den) but reserved the right to dress current obsession Kothari himself. Says Shetty, "I think he needs to involve

THE ONES WHO GOT AWAY

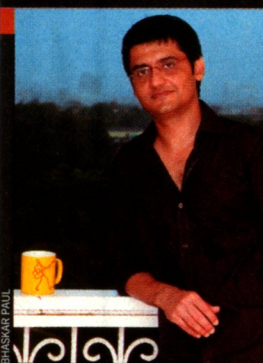
Ram Gopal Varma likes to work with stars but he also gives absolute newcomers a break.

MADHUR BHANDARKAR >>

He assisted Varma on three films—*Raat*, *Drohi* and *Rangeela*. Like him, the *Page 3* director loves movies. The two would discuss directors from Manmohan Desai to Mani Ratnam. Says Bhandarkar, "He knows what he wants, even when he is improvising on the sets."



MANOHAR DEODHAR



BHASKAR PAUL

<< JAIDEEP SAHNI

The writer of *Company* and *Jungle* went to co-produce *Khosla ka Ghosla* and write this year's most influential film, *Chak De! India* for YashRaj Films, a studio that is the antithesis of his school of filmmaking. Says he about Varma, "He loves underdogs."

ANURAG KASHYAP >>

The writer of *Satya*, *Kaun?* and *Shool*, he went on to make films such as *Paanch* and *Black Friday*. His craft with the language is something Varma misses, though he would not admit it.



BHASKAR PAUL

other people in the creative process." Varma's typical response? "What if my sound-ing boards are wrong? In any case, they keep changing."

When Bollywood was first gripped by corporatisation, in 2004, Varma had declared he wanted to release a new film every Friday. Total domination happens when there is total decentralisation—which Varma doesn't understand. Even now. As he says, "There is nothing wrong in the way I work. What went wrong is the ideas I picked up." Not quite though. If he didn't physically direct his assistants' films, he would sit in on the edit. If all the films they made looked the same, it was because he was not open to a different sensibility—one that might have appealed to a wider audience, especially in the all-important overseas market. Varma likes spin so much (*D* is the prequel to *Company*! *Naach* is my most personal film yet!) that he often buys into it. He also has an offhand attitude to money which means several professionals who've worked with him in the past are still to get paid. But he is generous with praise, if not money. When Sahni showed him the first cut of *Khosla ka Ghosla*, he liked it, even though he doesn't believe in what he calls the Sai Paranjapye-kind of com-

edy. When he saw *Page 3*, he called up Bhandarkar, even asking him for the number of an actor whom he used later.

He has been written off several times before. As he says, "I made an unexpected hit like *Satya* but I also made a big flop, *Daud*. I directed *Rangeela* but then I also made *Aag*. So who's the real Ram Gopal Varma?" Hmm. The last time he had a hit, *Sarkar* in 2005, it came after eight successive flops. Will its sequel, *Sarkar Raj*, made for Rs 20 crore and already pre-sold to Balaji Telefilms for Rs 35 crore, rescue him at the end of the year? Varma is nothing if not a genius escape artist, and much as he chuckles over the critical drubbing he is getting—the self-proclaimed PR guru firmly believes bad press is better than none—he also enjoys adulation. Perhaps all he needs to do is avoid the pre-release hype—a flood of exclusives promising a must-watch collaboration between Bachchan and Varma? Aargh. We can think of quite a few people who may want to skip that. ■